



Scaling Up Nutrition Academia and Research Institutions Network Uganda (SUN-ARINU): Report on the Launch of the Strategy 1.0 2026–2030

Venue: Sheraton Hotel

Activity Date: 21st May, 2026



Report Prepared by:

Aguma Leevan

(Research Technical Coordinator SUN-ARINU)

Approved by:

Peterson Kato Kikomeko, PhD.

(Chair SUN-ARINU)



Table of Contents

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY	3
2. INTRODUCTION	4
3. LAUNCH PROCEEDINGS	5
3.1. Welcome Remarks	5
3.2. Opening Remarks: GAIN Reflections on Academia–Industry Partnerships for Nutrition Systems Strengthening	7
3.3. Remarks by the Office of the Prime Minister: Mrs. Judith Orishaba	8
3.4. Keynote Speech	9
3.5. Keynote Panel Discussion	11
3.5.1. Keynote Panel Discussion: Plenary and Q&A Session	12
3.5.2. Keynote Panel Discussion: Panellist Responses and Resolutions	13
3.6. Academic-Industry Partnership Program Discussion	14
3.6.1. Student Innovations: Iris Nutrition Solutions	14
3.6.2. Dr. Jacent Asiimwe: Overview of Collaborative Frameworks	15
3.6.3. The IYCF Analysis Toolkit	16
3.6.4. Interns Award Ceremony	16
3.7. SUN-ARINU Strategic Plan 2026-2030	17
3.8. Partner and Institutional Remarks	20
3.8.1. Remarks from UNICEF	20
3.8.2. Message from Vice Chancellor Kyambogo University	21
3.8.3. Remarks by CASCADE Consortium Manager	22
3.9. Remarks by the Chief Guest	23
3.9.1. Recognition of strategic partnership	25
3.10. Official Launch Ceremony of SUN-ARINU Strategy 2026-2030	26
4. MAIN RECOMMENDATIONS (CALL TO ACTION)	26
5. Annex 1: Attached documents	28
6. Annex 2: Action Oriented Photos	28



1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

On 21st May 2026, the Scaling Up Nutrition Academia and Research Institutions Network Uganda (SUN-ARINU) officially launched its Strategy 1.0 (2026–2030) at the Sheraton Kampala Hotel. The event brought together government, development partners, academia, civil society, and the private sector and was presided over by Mr. Oyuku Dickens, representing the Permanent Secretary of the Ministry of Education and Sports.

The Strategy provides a five-year roadmap anchored on three pillars: mobilising academia and research institutions around national nutrition priorities; promoting interdisciplinary research and innovation; and strengthening evidence-to-policy translation. It is aligned with Uganda Vision 2040, NDP IV, the Uganda Nutrition Action Plan, and the SUN Movement Strategy 4.0 (2026–2030), among other regional and global frameworks.

Key themes across the proceedings included the urgency of closing the gap between research and policy, the growing burden of overweight and obesity alongside undernutrition, and the need for stronger national nutrition data systems. The launch also showcased the GAIN-supported university–industry internship programme, which produced UNBS-certified products and student-led enterprises, as well as the IYCF Analyse Toolkit for real-time field data analysis.

Implementation of the Strategy is estimated at UGX 11.15 billion over five years, with development partners committing approximately 30 percent of the required funding. The event concluded with the official signing of the Strategy and the presentation of partnership awards to the Office of the Prime Minister, Ministry of Education and Sports, UNICEF Uganda, CASCADE Consortium, and GAIN.

Stakeholders were urged to treat the launch as the beginning of a shared, accountable partnership, not a ceremonial milestone in the effort to end all forms of malnutrition in Uganda.



2. INTRODUCTION

The global Scaling Up Nutrition (SUN) Movement was established in 2010 to galvanize collective action towards a world free from malnutrition. Uganda joined the SUN Movement in 2011 and has since strengthened multisectoral nutrition governance by implementing two successive Uganda Nutrition Action Plans (UNAP I and II), positioning nutrition as a key driver of human capital development and national transformation.

As part of UNAP II implementation, SUN stakeholder networks, including development partners, civil society, academia, and the private sector, were established to leverage the comparative strengths of government. The Scaling Up Nutrition Academia and Research Institutions Network Uganda (SUN-ARINU), formed in 2023 and officially launched in May 2024 during the second National Nutrition Forum (NNF), was established to mobilize and coordinate academia and research institutions in generating, synthesizing, and translating evidence into nutrition policy and practice. Through collaboration, innovation, and knowledge sharing, the network seeks to ensure that nutrition actions in Uganda are informed by high-quality evidence and responsive to national priorities.

The launch of the SUN-ARINU Strategy 1.0 (2026–2030) marked a significant milestone in the network's growth and institutional development. The strategy provides a five-year roadmap for strengthening the contribution of academia and research institutions to Uganda's nutrition agenda. It is anchored on three strategic pillars: strengthening institutional coordination and membership engagement, promoting interdisciplinary nutrition research and innovation, and enhancing evidence-to-policy translation. The strategy aligns with Uganda Vision 2040, the Fourth National Development Plan (NDP IV), and the Uganda Nutrition Action Plan, ensuring that academic efforts contribute directly to national development goals. It is further informed by regional and global commitments, including the Comprehensive Africa Agriculture Development Programme (CAADP), the African Union Agenda 2063, the SUN Movement Strategy 4.0 (2026–2030), the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), the Nutrition for Growth Commitments and the World Health Assembly Global Nutrition Targets. This alignment ensures that academic and research efforts contribute directly to national development priorities while supporting regional and global commitments to nutrition, food systems transformation, and human capital development.

Held at the Sheraton Kampala Hotel, the launch brought together representatives from government ministries and agencies, development partners, academia, research institutions, civil society, and the private sector. Under the theme, *“Strengthening the Role of Academia and Research Institutions in Translating Evidence into Nutritional Action across Uganda’s Multisectoral Systems,”* the event highlighted the critical role of evidence generation, knowledge translation, and strategic partnerships in accelerating progress towards a well-nourished, healthy, and productive Uganda. This report



summarises the key proceedings, strategic discussions, and outcomes of the launch event.

3. LAUNCH PROCEEDINGS

3.1. Welcome Remarks

The General Secretary of the SUN-ARINU, Prof. Ivan Muzira Mukisa, welcomed participants to the official launch of the Network's Strategy 1.0 (2026–2030) and reflected on the critical role of academia and research institutions in translating evidence into action. He noted that Uganda continues to face a triple burden of malnutrition characterised by undernutrition, micronutrient deficiencies, and a growing prevalence of overweight and obesity.



Figure 1. Prof. Ivan Muzira Mukisa

Drawing on findings from the 2022 Uganda Demographic and Health Survey, he highlighted persistent regional disparities in child stunting, with several sub-regions recording prevalence rates above the World Health Organisation threshold of 30 percent, while overweight and obesity were rapidly increasing, particularly in urban areas. He emphasised that these challenges require systems-wide, evidence-based solutions that connect food, health, education, water and sanitation, and social protection systems.

Prof. Mukisa stressed that one of the key motivations behind establishing SUN-ARINU was to bridge the gap between knowledge generation and practical action, ensuring that research conducted within universities and research institutions informs policy, programming, and implementation. He described the Network as a mechanism for harnessing the collective expertise of academia and research institutions to contribute more effectively to Uganda's nutrition response and broader development agenda.

He provided a brief overview of the global Scaling Up Nutrition (SUN) Movement and highlighted Uganda's participation since 2011. He explained that SUN-ARINU forms part of Uganda's wider SUN architecture and works closely with the Government Network, SUN Civil Society Network, SUN Business Network, and the Development Partner Group to strengthen coordination, avoid duplication, and promote evidence-informed multisectoral nutrition action.

Reflecting on the Network's evolution, Prof. Mukisa highlighted that SUN-ARINU was formed in 2023 and officially launched in May 2024 through a process spearheaded by



the Office of the Prime Minister (OPM) and the Ministry of Education and Sports (MoES). He acknowledged the leadership of the OPM, particularly its role in facilitating the election of the inaugural Steering Committee, establishing governance and reporting structures, and integrating the Network into Uganda's national nutrition coordination framework. He further highlighted key milestones in the Network's development, including leadership orientation, constitution development, legal registration processes, participation in the National Nutrition Forum, and stakeholder consultations that culminated in the Strategy's development.

Looking ahead, he described the Strategy as a five-year roadmap for strengthening the contribution of academia and research institutions to Uganda's nutrition agenda. He outlined its three strategic pillars: mobilising academic and research institutions around common nutrition priorities, promoting interdisciplinary research and innovation, and strengthening evidence translation to inform policy and practice. He noted that the Strategy is aligned with Uganda Vision 2040, the Fourth National Development Plan (NDP IV), the Uganda Nutrition Action Plan, the SUN Movement Strategy 4.0, the Sustainable Development Goals, the CAADP Kampala Declaration, and Uganda's commitments under the Nutrition for Growth agenda.

In his concluding remarks, Prof. Mukisa expressed appreciation to the OPM, the MoES, the Catalysing Strengthened Policy Actions for Healthy Diets and Resilience (CASCADE) Consortium, the Global Alliance for Improved Nutrition (GAIN), Development partners, Civil Society, Private sector, member institutions, and all stakeholders who contributed technically and financially to the development of the Strategy. He called upon government, academia, development partners, civil society, and the private sector to invest in research, innovation, and capacity development, and urged all stakeholders to view the launch not as the end of a strategy development process, but as the beginning of a shared and accountable partnership to accelerate progress towards ending all forms of malnutrition in Uganda.



3.2. Opening Remarks: GAIN Reflections on Academia–Industry Partnerships for Nutrition Systems Strengthening

Ms. Damali Ssali, Country Director of GAIN Uganda, congratulated SUN-ARINU on the successful launch of its inaugural five-year strategy and commended the network for positioning academia and research institutions as critical contributors to Uganda's nutrition and development agenda. She acknowledged the leadership of the Office of the Prime Minister and the Ministry of Education and Sports in fostering an enabling environment for multisectoral nutrition action and appreciated the support of partners, including CASCADE, in strengthening the network's institutional foundations.



Figure 2. Ms. Damali Ssali-GAIN country director

She emphasised that effective nutrition systems require stronger linkages between evidence generation, innovation, and implementation. While academia generates research, knowledge, and innovations, industry provides opportunities for product development, technology uptake, market expansion, and the scaling of practical solutions. She noted that collaboration among academia, government, development partners, civil society, and the private

sector is essential to addressing Uganda's increasingly complex challenges in nutrition and food systems.

Ms. Ssali highlighted that Uganda's nutrition landscape extends beyond undernutrition to include broader food systems concerns such as the affordability of healthy diets, food safety, dietary diversity, climate-related food insecurity, urbanisation, and changing consumer behaviours. She stressed that sustainable progress in these areas requires coordinated action and stronger partnerships across sectors.

She further outlined GAIN's commitment to supporting private sector enterprises, food innovators, and nutrition-sensitive businesses as key actors in improving the availability, affordability, and accessibility of nutritious foods. She also highlighted GAIN's collaboration with institutions such as Kyambogo University and Makerere University in facilitating student internships and industry attachments, noting that these initiatives provide valuable exposure to real-world food systems, innovation ecosystems, and implementation environments. She called for the institutionalisation and expansion of academia–industry partnerships to strengthen workforce development, mentorship, and practical learning opportunities for students and young professionals.

Looking ahead, Ms. Ssali identified opportunities for collaboration in food innovation, food fortification, consumer and market research, nutrition-sensitive value chains,



workforce development, and implementation research. She commended SUN-ARINU for creating a national platform that brings together universities, research institutions, government, development partners, and other stakeholders to strengthen evidence-informed nutrition action. She reaffirmed GAIN's commitment to supporting partnerships that advance food systems transformation, nutrition innovation, evidence-informed programming, and sustainable nutrition outcomes for Uganda.

3.3. Remarks by the Office of the Prime Minister: Mrs. Judith Orishaba

Mrs. Judith Orishaba, representing the Office of the Prime Minister (OPM), congratulated SUN-ARINU on the successful launch of its Strategy 1.0 (2026–2030), describing the event as an important milestone in strengthening Uganda's multisectoral



Figure 3. Mrs. Judith Orishaba:
Office of the Prime Minister

nutrition coordination framework. She noted that the growing engagement of academia and research institutions in nutrition action demonstrates a strong national commitment to supporting evidence generation, innovation, training, and knowledge translation for improved nutrition outcomes. As the national coordinator of the Scaling Up Nutrition (SUN) Movement in Uganda, OPM reaffirmed its recognition that sustainable progress in addressing malnutrition requires strong collaboration across sectors, institutions, and stakeholders.

Mrs. Orishaba emphasised that Uganda's nutrition challenges cannot be addressed by a single ministry or sector, but instead require coordinated action across health, agriculture, education, water and sanitation, social protection, trade, local governments, academia, civil society, development partners, and the private sector. She explained that the SUN Networks were established under the Uganda Nutrition Action Plan framework to strengthen collaboration, coordination, and collective action among these stakeholder groups. Mrs. Orishaba noted that SUN-ARINU fills a critical gap within Uganda's nutrition coordination architecture by providing a structured platform through which universities, researchers, and academic institutions can contribute to evidence generation, policy dialogue, innovation, capacity development, and accountability systems.

She highlighted the pivotal role of academia and research institutions in strengthening evidence-informed decision-making and observed that effective nutrition programming must be guided by credible data, research, implementation science, and continuous learning. In this regard, she identified SUN-ARINU as a strategic partner in



strengthening Uganda's nutrition evidence ecosystem through research generation, nutrition data systems strengthening, data analysis, monitoring, evaluation and learning, policy development, knowledge translation, human resource capacity development, and innovation. She emphasized that robust nutrition data and evidence systems are essential for informing planning, tracking progress, strengthening accountability, and supporting effective implementation of nutrition interventions across sectors.

Mrs. Orishaba further commended the Strategy's alignment with the Uganda Nutrition Action Plan, the Fourth National Development Plan (NDP IV), Uganda Vision 2040, the Sustainable Development Goals, and the SUN Movement Strategy 4.0, noting that such alignment is essential for ensuring that research and innovation efforts remain responsive to national priorities and implementation needs. She expressed appreciation to the Ministry of Education and Sports for providing institutional anchorage to the Network and acknowledged the contributions of CASCADE, GAIN, UNICEF, government ministries and agencies, civil society organizations, development partners, and private sector actors in supporting SUN-ARINU and Uganda's broader nutrition agenda.

3.4. Keynote Speech

“Strengthening Academia and Research Leadership for Multisectoral Nutrition Action in Uganda” by Commissioner of Higher Education, Ministry of Education and Sports, Mr. Timothy Musoke Ssejjoba.

Mr. Timothy Musoke Ssejjoba, Director of Higher Education at the Ministry of Education and Sports (MoES) underscored the central role of nutrition in advancing Uganda's human capital development, productivity, educational attainment, and socio-economic transformation.



Figure 4. Mr. Timothy Musoke Ssejjoba

He observed that despite progress, Uganda continues to face multiple nutrition challenges, including child stunting, micronutrient deficiencies, overweight and obesity, as well as persistent regional disparities in nutrition outcomes. He noted that these challenges are complex and interconnected, requiring coordinated action across health, agriculture, education, water and sanitation, social protection, trade, research, and governance systems.

He emphasised the strategic position of academia and research institutions within Uganda's nutrition response, highlighting their

role in generating evidence, producing skilled human resources, advancing innovation



and technology, supporting implementation research, strengthening monitoring and evaluation systems, and facilitating knowledge translation. He described universities and research institutions as engines of national transformation and commended the Office of the Prime Minister for supporting the establishment of SUN-ARINU as a structured platform through which academia can collectively contribute to national nutrition priorities.

Mr. Ssejjoba further highlighted the persistent gap between research generation and practical implementation, noting that valuable evidence often remains confined to academic publications without adequately informing policy and programming. He called for more policy-responsive research, scalable innovations, stronger national evidence systems, and increased engagement between academic institutions, government, communities, and industry. He welcomed SUN-ARINU's strong focus on evidence translation and interdisciplinary collaboration as critical mechanisms for strengthening evidence-informed nutrition programming.

He stressed that malnutrition is driven by multiple determinants, including food insecurity, poverty, inadequate health services, poor water and sanitation, limited education, and social inequalities. In this regard, he commended the Strategy for adopting a systems approach that recognises the interconnectedness of food, health, education, WASH, and social protection systems. He encouraged greater interdisciplinary teaching and research, stronger partnerships between universities and government institutions, expanded engagement with the private sector and development partners, increased practical training and internship opportunities for students, and enhanced support for innovation and technology transfer.

The Director also commended the Strategy's alignment with national, regional, and global frameworks, including Uganda Vision 2040, the Fourth National Development Plan (NDP IV), the Uganda Nutrition Action Plan, the SUN Movement Strategy 4.0, the Sustainable Development Goals, and the Comprehensive Africa Agriculture Development Programme (CAADP). He noted that this alignment positions SUN-ARINU and its member institutions to contribute directly to Uganda's human capital development, agro-industrialisation, innovation, governance, and broader socio-economic transformation agenda.

Reaffirming the Ministry's commitment to supporting the network, Mr. Ssejjoba pledged continued support for capacity strengthening within higher education institutions, nutrition-sensitive training and curriculum development, research and innovation ecosystems, student engagement, and partnerships between academia, government, and industry. He concluded by calling upon universities, researchers, development partners, the private sector, and students to work collaboratively in generating evidence-informed, solution-oriented approaches that accelerate progress towards ending all forms of malnutrition in Uganda.



3.5. Keynote Panel Discussion

The panel discussion, moderated by Prof. Kaaya Archileo, Makerere University, had three discussants:

1. Mr. Phillip Pacutho shared the NPA perspectives on Priority Nutrition Investment and Implementation Areas Requiring Academia and Research Support in Uganda.
2. Mr. Habimana Robert shared the UBOS Perspectives on Strengthening National Evidence and Data Systems for Nutrition Action
3. Dr. Joweria Namboze of Kyambogo University discussed the Academia Perspectives on Strengthening Evidence-to-Policy Linkages through Research, Innovation, and Training

It focused on three key areas for institutional convergence in nutrition research and implementation. Priority Nutrition Investment and Implementation Areas Requiring Academia and Research Support in Uganda; Strengthening National Evidence and Data Systems for Nutrition Action; Strengthening Evidence-to-Policy Linkages through Research, Innovation, and Training.

Mr. Phillip Pacutho (National Planning Authority): He highlighted that the Fourth National Development Plan (NDP4) presents a wealth of research and innovation



Figure 5. Mr. Phillip Pacutho: National Planning Authority

opportunities for the SUN-ARINU network. He urged the network to focus on human capital development across the entire life cycle and to identify implementation bottlenecks by researching which entities are failing to deliver on nutrition goals. He advocated for a multidisciplinary systems approach to break institutional silos and suggested expanding the focus to Regional and Private Sector Development programs, where services directly reach the people. Finally, he called for the development of cost models to track government investment per mother during the "thousand days" window and emphasised the need to package research findings in a language that resonates with specific audiences, such as the Ministry of Finance.



Mr. Robert Habimana (Uganda Bureau of Statistics): He addressed the need to strengthen national data systems, noting that while the National Information Platform for Nutrition (NIPN) exists, it relies heavily on surveys and censuses that take too long to capture rapid nutritional changes. He proposed a shift toward integrating administrative and community data collected on a daily or monthly basis. He encouraged researchers to utilise emerging technologies such as AI, Geospatial Information Systems (GIS), satellite imagery, and web scraping to create a predictive platform capable of identifying potential hunger zones six months in advance.



Figure 6. Mr. Robert Habimana: Uganda Bureau of Statistics

Dr. Nambooze Joweria: Representing academic institutions and the Cascade project, Dr. Nambooze discussed how Kyambogo University has transitioned from traditional



Figure 7. Dr. Joweria Nambooze: Senior Lecturer, Kyambogo University

academic research to becoming a strategic research partner that informs policy. She highlighted collaborations with the NPA, the Ministry of Health, and the Ministry of Agriculture to ensure research has real-world implications. She specifically noted the success of the GAIN-supported internship program, which places students in the private sector to help small-scale food processors achieve UNBS certification while building the students' entrepreneurial skills.

3.5.1. Keynote Panel Discussion: Plenary and Q&A Session

The plenary session raised several critical questions regarding data integration, authenticity, and communication:



Data Integration and Authenticity: Ms. Judith Orishaba from the Office of the Prime Minister (OPM) asked how academic studies could be integrated into the NIPN dashboard and who would quality-assure this data to ensure it is authentic enough for government use. Mr. David from the Ministry of Agriculture echoed this concern, asking how valuable academic data could be authenticated by UBOS so it is not dismissed at the policy level.

Surveillance and Gaps: A participant inquired about the status of the 2027 Uganda Demographic and Health Survey (UDHS) and noted a significant data gap regarding anaemia and micronutrients, which have not been comprehensively updated since 2011 or 2016.

Early Warning Systems: There was a call for clarity on which agency would lead the development of early warning platforms to predict food insecurity. **Communication for Communities:** Participants asked how complex nutritional data could be repackaged for lay audiences, including children in schools and the elderly.

3.5.2. Keynote Panel Discussion: Panellist Responses and Resolutions

In response to the plenary, the panellists provided the following clarifications:

Authenticity and Standards: Mr. Robert Habimana (UBOS) explained that for data to be authenticated by the government, it must be nationally or regionally representative rather than based on small, generalised samples. He noted that UBOS has established a research unit specifically to coordinate with academia to harmonise these data sets.

Strategic Coordination: Phillip Pacutho (NPA) clarified that coordination for policy change should happen through the program working groups within the NDP4 framework.

Quality Assurance in Academia: Dr. Nambooze emphasised that academic research undergoes rigorous quality assurance through accredited research ethics committees and the National Council for Science and Technology. She also confirmed that Kyambogo University has developed expertise in cost models for implementation, which can be shared with the government.

Internship Sustainability: Dr Nambooze invited other universities to join the GAIN-supported internship program, noting that it is now in its third cohort and is a proven model for industrialising nutrition training.



3.6. Academic-Industry Partnership Program Discussion

The academia-industry partner discussion session, titled "Showcasing Academia Innovation and Industry Linkages," was a central feature of the SUN-ARINU Strategy 1.0 launch. Moderated by Dr. Christopher Mugaga from Gulu University, the session focused on how practical partnerships can transform nutrition students from job seekers into entrepreneurial job creators.

3.6.1. Student Innovations: Iris Nutrition Solutions

Two former interns from Kyambogo University, Natukunda Bridget Diana and Sonia Nambuya, shared their journey of



Figure 8. Ms. Natukunda Bridget Diana: Former Human Nutrition and Dietetics Student, Kyambogo University

transitioning from clinical nutrition internships at the university to a Small-Medium Enterprise (SME) engaged in food value addition, supported by GAIN.

Bridget reflected on her earlier internships in hospital settings, where she witnessed children dying from preventable nutrition-related complications in specialised nutrition wards. This experience motivated her to shift from clinical treatment to preventive nutrition.

During her final internship with the Cascade project and GAIN, she was attached to a small-scale fruit juice processor in Jinja, where she made several contributions. She successfully helped the small enterprise achieve UNBS (Uganda National Bureau of Standards) certification. She developed a range of new products, including items



Figure 9. Ms. Sonia Nambuya: Former Human Nutrition and Dietetics Student, Kyambogo University

specifically targeting anaemia in women and children, as well as healthy snacks designed to address overweight and obesity. She described the experience as finding her "Ikigai" (a Japanese concept for one's reason for being), a Japanese concept representing the intersection of her skills, her passion for entrepreneurship, and her mission to add value to society.



Sonia interned with Christ Produce Supplies in Mbale, where she gained technical skills in innovation, documentation, and marketing. She emphasised that the internship was a "win-win" for both the student and the business, as she provided technical expertise in standard operating procedures while gaining professional maturity.

Iris Nutrition Solutions

Drawing on their internship experiences, Bridget and Sonia co-founded Iris Nutrition Solutions to bring their innovative nutritional products to the market. Their company features two primary product lines. The Nourish Foods Line: This is a vegetable-based line focused on native Ugandan vegetables. Key products include Kunguma (available in ready-to-eat and powder forms), dried mushrooms, and other vegetable-based snacks. The "Thousand Days" Line: This second line specifically targets the critical window of opportunity for nutritional intervention, providing products for pregnant women, lactating mothers, and children under the age of two.

The students reported that their products are currently available in supermarkets in Jinja and Kampala, as well as through online marketplaces. They credited the collaboration between GAIN, Kyambogo University, and the private sector for providing the mentorship and practical environment necessary to transition from job seekers to job creators.

3.6.2. Dr. Jacent Asiimwe: Overview of Collaborative Frameworks

Dr Jacent Asiimwe provided a technical overview of how academia and industry can partner to develop skills. She emphasised that universities must adopt "Competence-Based Learning" to ensure graduates are employable and meet market demands. She detailed the GAIN-supported internship program, which placed students from Kyambogo and Makerere Universities into small-scale food processing businesses for three months. The students provided technical expertise in Good Manufacturing Practices (GMP) and Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs), helping these small businesses grow while gaining hands-on professional experience. Dr. Jacent Asiimwe highlighted that one student at Marata Grain Millers developed a composite flour for children under five that



Figure 10. Dr. Jacent Asiimwe



received UNBS approval, while another became a quality control officer for organic cereals.

3.6.3. The IYCF Analysis Toolkit

Mr. Magezi Robert Winks from Nutrition Innovate Teams presented the IYCF (Infant and



Figure 11. Mr. Robert Magezi

Young Child Feeding) Analyse Toolkit. This desktop software was designed to validate, analyse, and report IYCF data directly from the field, moving away from slow manual Excel analysis. The tool is aligned with WHO and UNICEF global standards, utilising all 17 IYCF indicators to provide real-time "plausibility reports" that can flag invalid data (such as inconsistent age or breastfeeding records) while the researcher is still in the field.

He made a live demonstration of how the desktop tool works by uploading sample data and showing its visual dashboard features, including indicators, food groups, and area graphs. The tool is available for download on <https://winxlibrary.com/>. The tool has already been utilised by the Cascade project and Kyambogo University for food security and nutrition assessments.

3.6.4. Interns Award Ceremony

The session concluded with an award ceremony where the three former outstanding



Figure 12. Group photo with Dr. Faith, Ms. Damali and the students after receiving their awards

student interns under the GAIN-University-Industry partnership received certificates of appreciation. The certificates were awarded in recognition of the students having been able to start their own enterprises and/or develop food products that are already on the market. Awarded students included Natukunda Bridget (second left), Sonia Nambuya (centre), and Boniface Okello (second right).



Awards were presented by the GAIN Country Director and the Head of the Nutritional Science and Dietetics Department, Kyambogo University, Dr. Faith Namayengo. In her remarks, Dr. Faith expressed gratitude to GAIN for the partnership that began in 2023. She noted that over seven students had benefited from the internship arrangement, and some had moved on to directly engage in the creation of dietetic products and the successful launch of student-led companies like Iris Nutrition Solutions.

Further remarks were made by Mr. Nick Obot (GAIN), described as the "man in the trenches" for the internship program. Nick confirmed that the model had proven its success. He challenged other universities to scale up and industrialise this model, urging students to use their knowledge to improve lives through innovation.

3.7. SUN-ARINU Strategic Plan 2026-2030

The Network Chairperson, Dr. Peterson Kato Kikomeko, began by welcoming all participants to the launch and thanked the Guest of Honour for agreeing to officiate at the event.



Figure 13. Dr. Peterson Kato Kikomeko

He expressed profound appreciation to the Office of the Prime Minister (OPM) and the Ministry of Education and Sports (MoES) for their leadership, stewardship, and continued support towards the establishment and growth of SUN-ARINU. He noted that the guidance provided by the two institutions had been instrumental in laying the foundation for a coordinated academia and research platform

capable of contributing meaningfully to Uganda's nutrition agenda.

He extended his appreciation to members of the Steering Committee and the broader SUN-ARINU membership for their dedication and commitment throughout the strategy development process. He further acknowledged the invaluable contributions of government ministries and agencies, universities, research institutions, development partners, civil society organisations, and private sector actors who participated in the consultations that informed the Strategy.

He described the Strategy as a transformative roadmap for strengthening the contribution of academia and research institutions to Uganda's nutrition agenda over the next five years.



Turning to the Strategy itself, Dr. Kikomeko noted that Uganda continues to face a triple burden of malnutrition characterised by persistent undernutrition, micronutrient deficiencies, and a rising prevalence of overweight, obesity, and diet-related non-communicable diseases. While progress has been made in reducing malnutrition, significant disparities persist across regions and population groups, underscoring the need for stronger evidence generation, innovation, and multisectoral action.

He emphasised that academia and research institutions possess a wealth of expertise and a broad range of research and innovation opportunities that can significantly contribute to addressing these challenges if effectively coordinated and linked to national priorities.

He explained that the Strategy was developed through a highly participatory process involving stakeholders from academia, government, development partners, civil society, and the private sector. The resulting five-year roadmap seeks to transform SUN-ARINU into a vibrant platform for nutrition training, research, innovation, and evidence translation, ensuring that knowledge generated within universities and research institutions contributes directly to policy development, programme implementation, and accountability mechanisms.

Dr. Kikomeko outlined the Strategy's vision, mission, and strategic direction, highlighting three core pillars that will guide implementation. The first pillar focuses on mobilising academia, researchers, and research institutions onto a common platform to support the implementation of national nutrition priorities. The second pillar promotes interdisciplinary and multisectoral research, training, and innovation to strengthen nutrition programming and accelerate the generation of practical solutions to Uganda's nutrition challenges. The third pillar seeks to strengthen the translation of research evidence into policy, advocacy, programming, and practice, thereby bridging the longstanding gap between knowledge generation and implementation.

He further explained that the Strategy is aligned with Uganda Vision 2040, the Fourth National Development Plan (NDP IV), the Uganda Nutrition Action Plan, the SUN Movement Strategy 4.0, the Sustainable Development Goals, the African Union Agenda 2063, and the Comprehensive Africa Agriculture Development Programme (CAADP). This alignment, he noted, positions SUN-ARINU as a strategic partner in advancing Uganda's human capital development, food systems transformation, and broader socio-economic development agenda.



The Chairperson also highlighted the governance and implementation arrangements that will underpin the Strategy, including the General Assembly, Steering Committee, Secretariat, Technical Working Groups, and regional coordination structures. He emphasised the importance of strategic partnerships, youth engagement, gender and social inclusion, digital transformation, communication and visibility, resource mobilisation, and monitoring and evaluation as critical enablers for successful implementation.

Regarding financing, Dr. Kikomeko informed participants that the estimated cost of implementing the Strategy over the five years is approximately UGX 11.15 billion. He explained that resources would be mobilised through a combination of government support, development partner contributions, competitive grants, strategic partnerships, membership contributions, and institutional investments by member organisations. He emphasised that achieving the Strategy's ambitions would require collective investment and sustained commitment from all stakeholders.

He recognised the CASCADE Consortium for financing the Strategy development process and the consultative engagements that culminated in the final document. He also thanked the GAIN for supporting the launch of the Strategy and for its continued collaboration in strengthening nutrition systems, innovation, and academia-industry partnerships. He further acknowledged the support of development partners, United Nations agencies, civil society organisations, and private sector stakeholders who have contributed to the growth of SUN-ARINU since its establishment.

In concluding his presentation, Dr. Kikomeko called upon government institutions, academia, development partners, United Nations agencies, civil society organisations, and the private sector to embrace the Strategy as a shared framework for action. He noted that the successful implementation of the Strategy would depend on strong partnerships, coordinated action, investment in research and innovation, and a collective commitment to ensuring that evidence generated by academia translates into tangible improvements in nutrition outcomes for all Ugandans.



3.8. Partner and Institutional Remarks

3.8.1. Remarks from UNICEF

Mrs. Mary Nabisere, a nutrition officer at UNICEF, delivered remarks on behalf of the development partners group. Her submission focused on institutional commitments, changing nutritional trends, and the vital role of research in addressing affordability.



Figure 14. Mrs. Mary Nabisere:
UNICEF

Mrs. Nabisere highlighted the UGX 11.15 billion budget required to implement the five-year Strategy, noting that the portion expected from development partners amounted to approximately UGX 600 million annually. She expressed confidence that this funding gap could be bridged through coordinated partner action, emphasising the need for resource pooling and aligned investments rather than fragmented efforts. She further pledged continued technical support from development partners to strengthen the research-policy interface and enhance the translation of evidence into action.

A key part of her submission highlighted a significant shift in nutritional challenges (Addressing the "Triple Burden" of Malnutrition). She noted that for the first time in history, overweight and obesity have surpassed under-nutrition among school-age children and adolescents both globally and locally in Uganda. She praised the strategy for focusing on obesity and overnutrition before the issue becomes unmanageable. She confirmed that the strategy aligns with UNICEF's systems approach, which integrates food, health, water and sanitation (WASH), education, and social protection.

Ms Nabisere used her submission to emphasise that many nutritional realities only become clear through rigorous evidence. She cited an ethnographic study implemented by Kyambogo University on behalf of UNICEF, which highlighted that while healthy food is visible, it remains unaffordable for millions of families. She shared a poignant quote from a mother in the study, "Eyes on the food, hands in the pocket", to illustrate that the desire for healthy food is often thwarted by a lack of financial access.



She concluded by calling for sustained, agile collaboration between young professionals, technical experts, and policymakers. She emphasised that the success of the strategy depends on translating evidence into meaningful policy and avoiding the fragmentation of resources.

3.8.2. Message from Vice Chancellor Kyambogo University

Dr. Peter Rukundo delivered a message on behalf of the Vice Chancellor of Kyambogo University, who was unable to attend the launch at the last minute. The communication underscored the university's deep commitment to the nutrition agenda and its role as a leader in academic research and innovation.

The Vice Chancellor expressed gratitude to the Office of the Prime Minister (OPM) and the Ministry of Education and Sports for their role in enabling academic and research institutions to unite through the SUN-ARINU network. He specifically recognised the Cascade Consortium, noting that the partnership provided approximately 1 million euros to Kyambogo University, which significantly bolstered the institution's commitment to nutrition and provided vital non-budget support. The message highlighted ongoing collaborations with several organisations, including GAIN, UNICEF, World Vision Uganda, Action Against Hunger (ACF), and the members of the Cascade Consortium.



Figure 15. Dr. Peter Milton Rukundo:
Kyambogo University

To support its goal of becoming a research-led institution, Kyambogo University has set aside 6 billion shillings specifically to support research conducted by staff and students. The Vice Chancellor invited SUN-ARINU to explore ways to access these existing grant funds for their activities. The university has established an incubation and innovation hub under the Faculty of Science to support both student innovators and the private sector. A dedicated budget line of 5 billion shillings per year has been allocated to support these innovation efforts.

The university has strengthened its academic offerings by establishing a PhD program in human nutrition, adding to its existing training levels in the field. Kyambogo is promoting innovations through its STEAM (Science, Technology, Engineering,



Agriculture, and Mathematics) festival, which is aligned with the national 10-fold growth strategy and supported by the Office of the President.

The Vice Chancellor urged the SUN-ARINU leadership to produce a detailed report of the launch for presentation at the Vice Chancellor's Forum. He believes this will serve as a tool for broader resource mobilisation and encourage other universities to appreciate and adopt the leading role Kyambogo has taken in the nutrition network.

3.8.3. Remarks by CASCADE Consortium Manager

The submission from the CASCADE Consortium manager Ms. Yossa Daisy Immaculate, focused on the successful testing of a new collaborative internship model and the need to institutionalise these successes across Uganda's higher education system. She characterised the CASCADE project as a "laboratory" that was used to test a prototype initiative for which the results presented at the launch proved that the model is both "scalable and fundable". She issued a strong call to action for other universities, specifically naming Mountains of the Moon, Uganda Christian University (UCU), and



**Figure 16. Mrs. Yossa Daisy Immaculate-
CASCADE Consortium Manager**

Nkumba to adopt the internship model. She urged these institutions to normalise placing students in private sector entities rather than just health facilities, noting that this expands employment prospects for students beyond the public sector. Immaculate emphasised that the ultimate measure of success would be for universities to institutionalise these practices so that such industry-linked internships become "part and parcel" of their standard academic work. She highlighted the critical role of partners within the consortium, specifically acknowledging CARE International in Uganda, GAIN, Nick (from GAIN), the Food Rights Alliance, the Africa Innovations Institute, and Kyambogo University. She concluded by pledging the

consortium's continued commitment to work with SUN-ARINU to develop new programs and to provide a table for developing and testing new academic and nutritional ideas.



3.9. Remarks by the Chief Guest

Permanent Secretary, Ministry of Education and Sports, delivered by Mr. Oyuku Dickens, Principal Inspector of Schools, Directorate of Education Standards

Mr. Oyuku Dickens, Principal Inspector of Schools, Directorate of Education Standards, represented the Chief Guest, the Permanent Secretary, Ministry of Education and Sports, and delivered remarks during the official launch and unveiling of the SUN-ARINU Strategy 1.0 (2026–2030). He described the launch as a significant milestone for both SUN-ARINU and Uganda’s broader multisectoral nutrition agenda, noting that it formally strengthens the role of academia and research institutions as strategic contributors within the national nutrition coordination framework.

He emphasised that higher learning institutions are “engines of national transformation” and occupy a unique position in generating evidence for policy, producing skilled human resources, and advancing innovations necessary for an effective national nutrition



Figure 17. Mr. Oyuku Dickens: Ministry of Education and Sports

response. He observed that while academia continues to generate valuable research, a persistent challenge remains in translating evidence into policy, planning, and implementation, with much research remaining confined to academic publications. He therefore called for more policy-relevant and solution-oriented research that responds directly to national realities and informs decision-making.

Mr. Oyuku noted that Uganda continues to face a complex nutrition burden characterised by undernutrition, micronutrient deficiencies, and increasing levels of overweight and obesity, requiring strong evidence systems, innovation, human resource capacity, and coordinated multisectoral action. Recognising that malnutrition is driven by interconnected factors including food insecurity, poverty, inadequate health services, and poor WASH conditions, he advocated for a systems approach involving collaboration across the food, health, education, social protection, and other



development sectors. He highlighted SUN-ARINU's role in mobilizing universities, researchers, and academic institutions to contribute to national nutrition priorities through research, training, innovation, interdisciplinary collaboration, and evidence translation, while strengthening the critical link between evidence generation and policy action.

He further noted the Strategy's alignment with Uganda Vision 2040, the Uganda Nutrition Action Plan, the National Development Plan IV, and the Sustainable Development Goals, positioning academia and research institutions as important partners in advancing human capital development and sustainable national transformation. On behalf of the Permanent Secretary, he commended the leadership of SUN-ARINU, the Office of the Prime Minister, CASCADE, GAIN, member institutions, and other partners for their contribution to the development of the Strategy and the growth of the Network. He reaffirmed that the Ministry of Education and Sports provides institutional anchorage to SUN-ARINU and remains committed to supporting capacity strengthening, curriculum development, student engagement, research and innovation ecosystems, and academia–industry partnerships. He called for stronger collaboration between SUN-ARINU, government ministries and agencies, development partners, civil society organisations, the private sector, and local governments to ensure that research, innovation, and evidence effectively inform nutrition policy and practice. He concluded by urging stakeholders to ensure that the launch becomes a catalyst for action rather than a ceremonial milestone, before officially launching and unveiling the SUN-ARINU Strategy 1.0 (2026–2030) on behalf of the Permanent Secretary, Ministry of Education and Sports.



3.9.1. Recognition of strategic partnership



Figure 18. Partners who received plaques pose for a group photo with the guest of honour

The following partners were presented with awards by the Guest of Honour:

1. Office of the Prime Minister (OPM): Honoured for their crucial role in the overall coordination of nutrition in Uganda and for inspiring the initial establishment of the SUN-ARINU network.
2. Ministry of Education and Sports: Recognised for providing the institutional anchorage and leadership that allowed the network to navigate its way since its inception.
3. UNICEF Uganda: Honoured for their long-standing support of scaling up nutrition efforts in the country and their commitment to assisting with the implementation of the new strategy.
4. CASCADE Consortium: Awarded in affirmation of the technical and financial support provided specifically toward the development of the SUN-ARINU Strategy
5. Global Alliance for Improved Nutrition (GAIN): Recognised for its instrumental role in supporting the official launch event and for its ongoing efforts in strengthening academia-industry collaborations.



Following the individual presentations, the recipients joined the Guest of Honour for a group photo to display the accolades, symbolising a shared commitment and multisectoral partnership toward ending malnutrition in Uganda

3.10. Official Launch Ceremony of SUN-ARINU Strategy 2026-2030



Figure 19. Mr. Oyuku Dickens signing the Strategy on behalf of PS MoES

The official unveiling was led by the Chief Guest, Mr. Dickens, representing the Permanent Secretary of the Ministry of Education and Sports.

The launch ceremony featured the symbolic removal of a ribbon and the official signing of the strategy document to reaffirm institutional and government commitments.

A wide array of stakeholders, including university representatives and high-level officials, added their signatures to the document and participated in commemorative group photographs. The event concluded with a closing prayer and an invitation for guests to view the student-led nutrition products on display.

4. MAIN RECOMMENDATIONS (CALL TO ACTION)

- Develop and finalise a prioritised national nutrition research agenda in collaboration with relevant ministries (MOH, MAAIF, MOES, etc.) and stakeholders, incorporating inputs from UNICEF, NPA, UBOS, and others.
- Establish a research repository and/or digital knowledge hub for sharing research outputs, innovations, and policy briefs, and work with OPM and UBOS to integrate with the national NIPN platform.
- Work with UBOS and OPM to improve the timeliness and real-time functionality of the national nutrition information platform (NIPN), including integration of



administrative and real-time data, and support for predictive analytics/early warning systems.

- Collaborate with the Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and Fisheries to strengthen data systems and research linkages in the agriculture and food production sectors.
- Support and scale up the GAIN-supported student internship program with private sector entities, and work with universities to institutionalise similar programs as part of competence-based education (CBE).
- Support the development, adoption, and scaling of tools such as the IYCF Analyse software, in partnership with Innovative Teams and other stakeholders, for improved data quality and real-time analysis in infant and young child feeding.
- Engage with the Vice Chancellors' Forum and university management to secure funding from existing university research budgets (e.g., Kyambogo University's 6 billion shillings research fund) for SUN-ARINU activities.
- Strengthen linkages and joint programming with the private sector, including SMEs, to support product development, standards compliance, and market access for nutritious foods.
- Work with UBOS to develop streamlined research protocols and quality assurance mechanisms so that research from academia is recognised and utilised for national policy and programming.
- Support the integration of data systems across key ministries (Health, Education, Water, Gender, etc.) to ensure interoperability and comprehensive nutrition monitoring
- Support the development and implementation of cost models for nutrition interventions, in partnership with relevant government agencies and development partners.
- Support and recognise student and young professional innovation in nutrition, including through incubation centres and start-up support (e.g., Iris Nutrition Solutions)



5. Annex 1: Attached documents



Final SUN_ARINU
Strategy Presentatio



SUNARINU LAUNCH
PRESENTATION JAK, r

6. Annex 2: Action Oriented Photos









